

New Generation English B· Diagnostic Test

B1 (Intermediate Strong) B· Full Test

READING

The slow return of letter writing

For about fifteen years almost no one wrote letters by hand. Email had taken over, then messengers, then voice notes. Even birthday cards were quietly disappearing. Yet in the last three or four years a small but visible group of people – most of them under thirty – have started writing letters again.

What surprised researchers was not the trend itself but who was driving it. The new letter-writers were not nostalgic older people; they were the same generation that grew up with smartphones. In interviews they often describe the same shift: a tiredness with the speed of digital messages, a wish for something slower, and a desire to send something that the receiver cannot delete with one tap.

There is also a quieter cultural reason. Several writers, including some Russian and British essayists, have argued that a hand-written letter forces a kind of attention that has become rare. You cannot easily multitask while writing one. You cannot change it after sending. The slowness is the point.

This does not mean that letters will replace messengers, of course. They will not. But the recent revival shows something interesting about digital fatigue: when a technology saturates everyday life, even small analogue alternatives start to feel meaningful again. Letter writing has become, for some people, a small ritual of paying attention – to one person, for one moment.

1. For about how many years did almost no one write letters by hand?

A) Five.

B) Fifteen.

C) Fifty.

2. Who are the new letter-writers mostly?

A) People over seventy.

B) People under thirty.

C) Schoolchildren.

3. What surprised researchers?

A) The growth of email.

B) Who was driving the revival.

C) The collapse of postal services.

4. What is one common feeling the new letter-writers describe?

A) Boredom with paper.

B) A tiredness with the speed of digital messages.

C) A love of high-tech writing apps.

5. What can the receiver NOT do with a letter?

A) Delete it with one tap.

B) Read it twice.

C) Show it to a friend.

6. What kind of attention does the letter force, according to several writers?

A) Distracted attention.

B) A kind of attention that has become rare.

C) Mechanical attention.

7. Will letters replace messengers, according to the text?

A) Yes, completely.

B) No, they will not.

C) Only in business.

8. What has letter writing become for some people?

A) A new commercial product.

B) A small ritual of paying attention.

C) An old-fashioned mistake.

LISTENING

Podcast interview: City Things, with urban beekeeper Olga

Script:

Host: Welcome back to City Things. Today we are talking to Olga, who has been an urban beekeeper in Moscow for almost six years. Olga, thank you for joining us. Many of our listeners are surprised that beekeeping is even possible in a city.

Olga: I understand the surprise. When I started in 2020, my own family thought I was joking. But honestly, the bees do not care that they are in Moscow. They care about flowers, water and a calm hive entrance. All three are available on a rooftop near the Garden Ring.

Host: What was the hardest part of the first year?

Olga: Two things. The first was technical — I had read several books, but books cannot show you how a swarm sounds at six in the morning. The second was social. Some neighbours were nervous about the bees. I learned to talk to them carefully, to invite them up, to show that the hive was calm. After two seasons, no one complained.

Host: And what surprised you most?

Olga: That the bees changed me more than I changed the rooftop. I used to think faster was always better. Now I think faster is sometimes just louder. Beekeeping teaches you to slow down without becoming passive.

1. How long has Olga been an urban beekeeper?

- A) About two years.
- B) Almost six years.**
- C) More than ten years.

2. What did Olga's family initially think?

- A) That she was joking.**
- B) That she was wasting money.
- C) That she had moved abroad.

3. What three things, according to Olga, do bees actually care about?

- A) Flowers, water and a calm hive entrance.**
- B) Quiet neighbours, sun and grass.
- C) Music, water and warm air.

4. What were the two hardest things in her first year?

- A) Money and weather.
- B) Something technical and something social.**
- C) Family and noise.

5. What could books not show her?

- A) How a swarm sounds at six in the morning.**
- B) How to read a calendar.

C) How to drive to the rooftop.

6. How did Olga reassure the nervous neighbours?

A) She wrote them a formal letter.

B) She invited them up and showed that the hive was calm.

C) She moved the hive to another building.

7. What did Olga used to think about speed?

A) That slower was better.

B) That faster was always better.

C) That speed did not matter.

8. How does Olga sum up the lesson of beekeeping?

A) It teaches you to slow down without becoming passive.

B) It teaches you to earn more.

C) It teaches you to leave the city.

WRITING

Write 130-160 words about an unusual hobby or profession (your own, a friend's, or one you have read about). Explain: how the person became involved, what they have learned from it, and one thing the rest of us could learn from them.

SPEAKING

Record 2 minutes. Talk about a hobby or activity that has surprised you — your own or someone else's. Explain how it started, what was difficult at first, and how it has changed your view of useful or important time.

